

The School Boy



POEM TEXT

1 I love to rise in a summer morn,
 2 When the birds sing on every tree;
 3 The distant huntsman winds his horn,
 4 And the skylark sings with me:
 5 O what sweet company!

 6 But to go to school in a summer morn,—
 7 O it drives all joy away!
 8 Under a cruel eye outworn,
 9 The little ones spend the day
 10 In sighing and dismay.

 11 Ah then at times I drooping sit,
 12 And spend many an anxious hour;
 13 Nor in my book can I take delight,
 14 Nor sit in learning's bower,
 15 Worn through with the dreary shower.

 16 How can the bird that is born for joy
 17 Sit in a cage and sing?
 18 How can a child, when fears annoy,
 19 But droop his tender wing,
 20 And forget his youthful spring!

 21 O father and mother if buds are nipped,
 22 And blossoms blown away;
 23 And if the tender plants are stripped
 24 Of their joy in the springing day,
 25 By sorrow and care's dismay,—

 26 How shall the summer arise in joy,
 27 Or the summer fruits appear?
 28 Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
 29 Or bless the mellowing year,
 30 When the blasts of winter appear?

But going to school on a summer morning—that spoils my happiness! Beneath the cruel eye of a weary teacher, the little students sigh and feel depressed all day.

Sometimes I sit there for hours, slumped and full of anxiety. I can't take any pleasure in my school book, nor can I learn there; it's like I'm sitting under trees that have been worn down by rain.

How can a bird that's born for a life of happiness and freedom possibly flourish in a cage? In an environment filled with fear, how can kids do anything but cower like vulnerable birds, and lose their youthful spirit?

Oh, my parents: if youth's potential is nipped in the bud, its flourishing cut off, its happiness stolen early and replaced by grief and hardship—how will the springtime of youth flower into a happy, healthy, productive adulthood? How will the full-grown adults harvest anything from life's sorrows, or enjoy their later years, once they're faced with the challenges of old age?



THEMES



EDUCATION, PLAY, AND FREEDOM

William Blake's "The School Boy" adopts the voice of a child who is unhappy and restless at school. This schoolboy would much rather play outside in the summer sunshine than stay indoors learning. With great sympathy, the poem portrays his summer schooling—and in many ways his school system—as a form of "cruel" captivity. It compares the boy to a gloomy "bird [...] in a cage," implying that play, independence, and freedom are healthier for children (especially during summer!) than formal education. In Blake's view, cooping kids up in a classroom is not only harsh but unnatural: it crushes their spirits and hinders their development as people.

From the start, the poem sides with the schoolboy who longs to play outdoors, noting how he's "joy[ful]" when playing outside but "anxious" and "dismay[ed]" in the classroom. He's happy enough to "sing[]" when he wakes in the morning, yet feels restless and oppressed once he's under the "cruel eye" of the schoolteacher. He can't take any "delight" in his "book," either; the sunny weather is so alluring that "learning[]" is effectively impossible. In fact, being trapped in this classroom makes him more *like* the "outworn" teacher: "drooping," weary, and sad. He can't be a healthy, happy kid here, as he later insists to his parents.

Indeed, the schoolboy—and the poem—argues that school in



SUMMARY

I love getting out of bed on a summer morning, when all the trees are full of chirping birds. Far off, a hunter blows his horn, and the skylark's song blends with my own singing. What wonderful companionship!

summertime is basically a prison for children. Rather than accelerating kids' development, it shuts down their progress and causes them "sorrow." The schoolboy compares himself to a "cage[d]" bird who is "born for joy" but cannot "sing" under these punishing conditions. In other words, the summer schoolroom makes him miserable and prevents him from reaching his potential. Unlike the "skylark" who "sings with [him]" when he's outside, he feels trapped here—unable to express or enjoy himself at all.

The poem implies, then, that a strict, dour approach to education thwarts children's actual needs and inclinations. It's as unnatural and wrong as locking up a free bird. And some of this criticism can be read as applying to the entire school system of Blake's time—not just summer school.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-30



CHILDHOOD POTENTIAL VS. MATURITY

"The School Boy" ends with an [extended metaphor](#) linking the joys of childhood with the potential rewards of adulthood. Through this metaphor, the schoolboy speaker warns that inhibiting children's "joy" will prevent them from fulfilling their potential. Moreover, it will keep them from blossoming into healthy, resilient adults capable of withstanding all the challenges maturity brings. By extension, the poem argues that childhood experience, good or bad, profoundly shapes adult life. Respecting kids' independence will cause them to blossom; cruelly regimenting their lives will "nip[]" their potential in the "bud[]."

The poem protests that school is shutting down, not nourishing, the schoolboy's potential. Like a caged "bird," the schoolboy feels he has no choice but to "droop his tender wing / And forget his youthful spring!" In other words, he's forced to grow up too soon, before he has a chance to play, explore the world, and develop to his fullest. There's a [metaphorical](#) connection here with the "hunter" mentioned at the start of the poem. Just as the hunter shoots down birds, the school threatens to kill the boy's youthful promise (by crushing his joy).

The schoolboy's closing speech, therefore, is a plea for the adults in his life to nourish his potential—just by letting him be a kid. In an extended metaphor, he warns his "father and mother" that "if buds are nipped" too early, they can't grow into the fruits of "summer" and the harvest season. In other words, if children aren't allowed to be children, they'll never grow into healthy and functional adults. Strictness and cruelty toward children won't toughen them up, the schoolboy warns; in fact, it will make them *less* resilient. If "tender plants"—that is, young kids—"are stripped / Of their joy" in youth, they'll be much more

vulnerable to "griefs" and "the blasts of winter" later on. They won't have developed the independent spirit necessary to weather life's harshest events.

Though these ideas may strike some modern parents and teachers as common sense, they broke from the prevailing wisdom of Blake's time. Strict schooling, rigid discipline, and child labor were all common in late-18th century and early 19th-century England. The poem therefore represents a plea for reform. Blake's choice of a young "School Boy" speaker, protesting on his own behalf, is a further attempt to honor the dignity and individuality of children.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 16-30



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-5

*I love to rise in a summer morn,
When the birds sing on every tree;
The distant huntsman winds his horn,
And the skylark sings with me:
O what sweet company!*

The poem begins on a joyful note. The title "The School Boy," combined with the speaker's childlike exuberance, signals that this is a dramatic monologue: a poem voiced by a character separate from the poet. In other words, the speaker here is a schoolboy—an unnamed, average, school-aged child in William Blake's 18th-century England—not Blake himself.

Like many children, this schoolboy is a fan of summer. He declares that he "love[s] to rise in a summer morn"—in other words, he loves waking up on summer mornings. He delights in hearing "the birds sing on every tree" (a sign that he lives in the countryside, where there are lots of trees around). As he enthuses about the season, [alliteration](#) adds a gentle musicality to his language, so that the lines themselves seem to "sing":

The distant huntsman winds his horn,
And the skylark sings with me:
O what sweet company!

Those soft /h/ and /s/ sounds make the phrases themselves sound "sweet" and [euphonious](#). The "huntsman" is a hunter of foxes or other game, "wind[ing]"—that is, blowing—his "horn" as a signal to his dogs or fellow hunters. Again, this detail evokes a rural [setting](#)—a pastoral landscape that the boy would like to be out enjoying, just as the hunter is. Meanwhile, a "skylark" seems to "sing[]" along with the boy in the trees or sky above. (Larks are famously active during the early morning hours.)

Together, the huntsman and the lark seem to make for "sweet

company," or wonderful companionship. But there's a touch of [irony](#) here, since the hunter is "distant" and the bird isn't human; in other words, the boy doesn't actually have any friends around. He may, in fact, be a little desperate for some "company." And as the rest of the poem makes clear, his joy in the morning is only too brief. He can't go out and play on this "summer morn," nor will he be "sing[ing]" for most of the day. He has to go to school instead.

LINES 6-10

*But to go to school in a summer morn,—
O it drives all joy away!
Under a cruel eye outworn,
The little ones spend the day
In sighing and dismay.*

In lines 6-10, the boy's exuberance quickly fades. He can't go out and play; he has "to go to school." Indeed, the poem's title has defined him as a "School Boy," as if it's a label he can't escape.

The first line of this [stanza](#) partly echoes the first line of the poem, but the [repetition](#) comes with an important variation:

But to go to school in a summer morn,—
O it drives all joy away!

Whereas the boy loves "to rise in a summer morn" (line 1), he hates "to go to school in a summer morn." School kills his upbeat mood; it "drives all" his "joy away." And he's not alone. Evidently, all his fellow students suffer under the "cruel eye" of their "outworn" (that is, worn-out) teacher. Rather than playing, having fun, and being kids, "The little ones spend the day / In sighing and dismay." They're all miserable together.

In fact, thanks to the ambiguous syntax here, the word "outworn" could apply to the *students* rather than the teacher. If it's the "little ones" who are worn out, it's because their "cruel" teacher has exhausted them. (Perhaps the teacher has given them too much work, disciplined them too strictly, and/or intimidated them to the point where they're emotionally depleted.) Far from providing any kind of stimulation, school has crushed these kids' "joy" and made them tired beyond their years.

LINES 11-15

*Ah then at times I drooping sit,
And spend many an anxious hour;
Nor in my book can I take delight,
Nor sit in learning's bower,
Worn through with the dreary shower.*

In lines 11-15, the speaker continues to protest his miserable school experience. He explains that he has "spen[t] many an anxious hour" in his classroom, "drooping" with dejection. He can't take any pleasure ("delight") in his schoolbook, or really

learn in that environment at all.

Turning to [metaphor](#), he says that school prevents him from "sit[ting] in learning's bower," which has been "Worn through with the dreary shower." A bower is a pleasant, shady spot in a garden or grove, so he means that the atmosphere of the schoolroom has destroyed the pleasure of learning. Rather than feeling at ease as he studies, he feels as if he's sitting under trees worn down by rain. He's uncomfortable, gloomy, and nervous.

His language here implies that he *could* "take delight" in his book, and enjoy "learning's bower," under the right circumstances. In other words, he's not simply an apathetic student. It's just that he can't learn properly under *these* circumstances. One reason, clearly, is the "cruel" teacher he mentioned earlier; another is the beautiful summer weather. Even the most eager students would rather play outside on sunny days like these! Children need recreation and relaxation outside the classroom, not only for their own health and pleasure but in order to focus on their learning. But this school system, the poem implies, isn't meeting their needs. Instead, it's keeping students cooped up and demanding too much of them. (In this way, Blake's poem can be read as a critique of 18th-century English schools in general.)

LINES 16-20

*How can the bird that is born for joy
Sit in a cage and sing?
How can a child, when fears annoy,
But droop his tender wing,
And forget his youthful spring!*

In lines 16-20, the schoolboy begins asking a series of [rhetorical questions](#), which will carry through to the end of the poem. As line 21 will reveal, he's addressing these questions to his mother and father. His [tone](#) is both plaintive and indignant as he tries to convince his parents that school is hurting him, not helping him. (At least in the summertime!)

Strong [alliteration](#) makes the first question especially forceful and memorable:

How can the bird that is born for joy
Sit in a cage and sing?

The boy is comparing himself, [metaphorically](#), to a bird in a cage: a free spirit who feels trapped and repressed. His question implies that there's no way for him to flourish ("sing"), or feel his natural mood of "joy," in his current classroom environment. More broadly, it implies that *all* children forced to sit through summer school are like birds in cages. Their confinement is uncomfortable, unhealthy, and unnatural. The second question turns this comparison into an [extended metaphor](#):

How can a child, when fears annoy,
But droop his tender wing,
And forget his youthful spring!

In other words, how can a child who's harassed by "fears"—such as the fear of a cruel teacher—help but lose his "youthful" energy and exuberance? In such a harsh learning environment, the boy suggests, *any* kid will suffer, like a "tender" and vulnerable bird "droop[ing]" its "wing" in pain. (Or just slumping sadly inside its cage.)

Note that in this version of the text, this last sentence is punctuated with an exclamation mark, but it's still a rhetorical question. In Blake's original 18th-century version, which used an older style of punctuation, all the questions ended with periods!

LINES 21-25

*O father and mother if buds are nipped,
And blossoms blown away;
And if the tender plants are stripped
Of their joy in the springing day,
By sorrow and care's dismay,—*

In lines 21-25, the schoolboy begins to address his "father and mother" directly. Perhaps he's been addressing them this whole time and is just now mentioning them. In any case, he's no longer protesting in a general way; he's essentially begging his parents to take him out of school.

As he pleads his case, he launches into another [extended metaphor](#), this time playing on the familiar [idiom](#) "nipped in the bud":

O father and mother if buds are nipped,
And blossoms blown away;
And if the tender plants are stripped
Of their joy in the springing day,
By sorrow and care's dismay,—

To *nip something in the bud* is to end something early, or to cut off its potential prematurely (as if removing the bud from a flowering plant). Here, the schoolboy is talking about his youthful enthusiasm, as well as his overall human potential. He worries that school will destroy these things prematurely, like a strong wind "blow[ing] away" the "blossoms" of a flower. He fears that all his "joy" will be "stripped" away from him in the springtime of his life ("the springing day"), and permanently replaced with "sorrow and care's dismay" (i.e., misery and anxiety). In short, he fears that instead of nurturing his potential, his education will snuff it out.

And his sentence doesn't end there; it's part of a larger [rhetorical question](#), which he'll complete in the next and final [stanza](#).

LINES 26-30

*How shall the summer arise in joy,
Or the summer fruits appear?
Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
Or bless the mellowing year,
When the blasts of winter appear?*

In lines 26-30, the speaker completes the [extended metaphor](#) he began in the previous [stanza](#). Lines 26-27 also complete the [rhetorical question](#) that began with "if buds are nipped, / And blossoms blown away":

How shall the summer arise in joy,
Or the summer fruits appear?

Figuratively, then, the schoolboy is asking: if happiness is thwarted in childhood, how can the child blossom into a happy, healthy adult? How can the "summer" of anyone's life be "joy[ful]" and "fruit[ful]" if they were abused and discouraged during the "spring[]" of their youth (see line 24)? And he is asking all this, of course, in connection with education. So the larger point of his question is that harsh, cruel, excessive schooling will produce joyless and unsuccessful adults. School should *nourish* kids' potential, not cut it off.

His final question builds on this idea, using forceful [alliteration](#) to drive the point home:

Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
Or bless the mellowing year,
When the blasts of winter appear?

Now his concern is with old age—the "mellowing" autumn and "winter" of one's life. If school crushes kids' spirits, the schoolboy wonders, how can they possibly survive the challenges of their later years? The phrase "gather what griefs destroy" evokes a [metaphorical](#) harvest: the fruits of one's labor, love, and life in general. We have to make and secure this legacy ("gather" its fruits), the metaphor implies, before hardships ("griefs") ruin it. But if we're thwarted early on, this harvest will be disappointing to begin with—and "the blasts of winter," or the hardships of old age, will wreck it altogether. Our life will be a failure.

Overall, then, the boy (and the poem) makes the case that childhood experiences overwhelmingly shape one's later life. Childhood education, in particular, is crucial. If schooling is strict, excessive, punitive, and so on, students will never reach their full potential. In fact, abusive schooling can completely "strip[]" away qualities (such as "joy" and enthusiasm) that serve students well in later life. Conversely, the poem suggests that lenient schooling, along with plenty of outdoor recreation, allows children to blossom to their fullest. In short: let kids play outside, especially in summer!



SYMBOLS



THE HUNTSMAN AND SKYLARK

The "hunter" and "skylark" in the first [stanza](#) are actual features of the schoolboy's [setting](#), but they also take on [symbolic](#) meaning over the course of the poem.

The skylark represents freedom and joy; it "sings" along with the boy when he wakes up in summertime. Unlike the boy, however, it doesn't have to go to school. Later in the poem, the boy compares himself to a "bird" in a "cage" as he languishes in school. He imagines him, and children like him, "droop[ing]" their "tender wing[s]" in this cruel environment. By now, the skylark represents all the freedom and joy the schoolboy *doesn't* have. Larks are also, famously, morning birds, so they may be associated here with the early years (the morning) of the boy's life—in other words, the youth he's wasting in the classroom.

In this context, the "hunter" might represent the *threats* facing innocence, joy, freedom, etc. This hunter could be hunting foxes or other game, not birds in particular. But he's a reminder that humans (adults in particular) are always trying to control and/or harm natural creatures (and children are often associated with the innocent, intuitive, "natural," etc.).

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 3-4:** "The distant huntsman winds his horn, / And the skylark sings with me:"



POETIC DEVICES

REPETITION

"The School Boy" uses several kinds of [repetition](#), mainly for the purposes of emphasis and comparison/contrast.

First, it repeats a number of thematically important words, including "summer" (four times), "bird"/"birds" (twice), "sing"/"sings" (three times), and "joy" (four times). All of these words relate to the speaker's natural, youthful exuberance—what he feels in the morning and *would* feel the rest of the day, if not for school. Essentially, he wants to be as joyful as a bird singing in summer! And while school hasn't crushed his spirit yet, it's coming dangerously close. ("Summer" weather and "birds" are also literal features of the poem's [setting](#).)

In lines 1 and 6, repetition helps the speaker draw this emotional contrast more directly. Whereas the schoolboy "love[s] to rise in a summer morn," he hates "to go to school in a summer morn." The [parallel](#) phrasing here emphasizes that summer *should* delight this child, but thanks to school, has

disappointed him instead.

Finally, the poem uses [anaphora](#) to drive home the speaker's points and underline his frustration. In the fourth [stanza](#), for example, the repeated "How can" suggests a tone of pleading or indignation:

How can the bird that is born for joy
Sit in a cage and sing?
How can a child, when fears annoy,
But droop his tender wing, [...]

Similarly, the last stanza repeats "Or" to convey an insistent tone, and to suggest a pile-up of potential consequences:

How shall the summer arise in joy,
Or the summer fruits appear?
Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
Or bless the mellowing year,
When the blasts of winter appear?

If his youthful exuberance is suppressed, the boy warns, he won't flourish in his early or later adulthood—the "summer" or the "winter" of his life.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "in a summer morn,"
- **Line 2:** "birds," "sing"
- **Line 4:** "sings"
- **Line 6:** "in a summer morn,"
- **Line 7:** "joy"
- **Line 13:** "Nor"
- **Line 14:** "Nor"
- **Line 16:** "How can," "bird," "joy"
- **Line 17:** "sing"
- **Line 18:** "How can"
- **Line 22:** "And"
- **Line 23:** "And"
- **Line 24:** "joy"
- **Line 26:** "summer," "joy"
- **Line 27:** "Or," "summer"
- **Line 28:** "Or"
- **Line 29:** "Or"

EXTENDED METAPHOR

The poem contains two [extended metaphors](#). The first covers the full fourth [stanza](#) (lines 16-20), while the second stretches across the fifth and six stanzas (lines 21-30). These metaphors develop over the course of the schoolboy's [rhetorical questions](#), which he addresses to his parents. (See the Rhetorical Question entry in this section for more.)

In the first extended metaphor, the boy compares himself to a caged bird—in other words, a free spirit who's been locked

away:

How can the bird that is born for joy
Sit in a cage and sing?
How can a child, when fears annoy,
But droop his tender wing,
And forget his youthful spring!

In other words, the boy is like the bird and the school is like his cage. But the speaker develops this simple idea further, suggesting that the pressure of "fears," in particular, will cause him (along with other "tender," vulnerable kids) to "droop" and lose his "youthful spring." That is, he will *languish* in school, as an unhappy bird does in captivity; he will lose his childlike qualities and grow up too soon.

The second metaphor plays on a familiar [idiom](#). The boy worries that his youthful potential will be, as the saying goes, *nipped in the bud*—cut off before it has a chance to develop:

O father and mother if buds are nipped,
And blossoms blown away;
And if the tender plants are stripped
Of their joy in the springing day,
By sorrow and care's dismay,—
How shall the summer arise in joy,
Or the summer fruits appear?
Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
Or bless the mellowing year,
When the blasts of winter appear?

Again, this metaphor takes a simple, familiar idea and elaborates on it. The boy worries that not only his potential but his youthful "joy" will be prematurely "stripped" away from him. He wonders how, under these circumstances, he can possibly mature into a healthy, happy adult—how the "summer" of his life can possibly be "joy[ful]" or "fruit[ful]." Finally, he worries about facing the metaphorical "blasts of winter"—the hardships of old age—down the line. He suggests if his youthful exuberance gets "stripped" or "nipped" away, he'll be more *vulnerable* to these hardships, as if facing them without a necessary layer of resilience.

Where Extended Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 16-20:** "How can the bird that is born for joy / Sit in a cage and sing? / How can a child, when fears annoy, / But droop his tender wing, / And forget his youthful spring!"
- **Lines 21-30:** "O father and mother if buds are nipped, / And blossoms blown away; / And if the tender plants are stripped / Of their joy in the springing day, / By sorrow and care's dismay,— / How shall the summer arise in joy, / Or the summer fruits appear? / Or how shall we gather

what griefs destroy, / Or bless the mellowing year, /
When the blasts of winter appear?"

RHETORICAL QUESTION

The poem contains four [rhetorical questions](#), which, together, span the entire second half of the poem. The first two occur in the fourth [stanza](#), as the boy introduces a [metaphor](#) about his unhappiness at school:

How can the bird that is born for joy
Sit in a cage and sing?
How can a child, when fears annoy,
But droop his tender wing,
And forget his youthful spring!

These questions are intended not to seek information but to make a point. The boy is comparing himself to a caged bird and asking, in effect, how he can possibly flourish in this dreary classroom environment. He warns that the "fears" he contends with at school (e.g., fears of his teacher) will ultimately cost him his childlike exuberance—his "youthful spring."

(Note that, in Blake's [original illustrated text](#), all of the poem's questions were punctuated with periods. In this modernized version, one of them is punctuated with a question mark and one with an exclamation mark, but they are both rhetorical questions. Different modern editors make different punctuation choices.)

In the last two stanzas, the boy's questions add up to another [extended metaphor](#) about the costs of a bad education. If "sorrow" and "care[]"—misery and anxiety—"nip[]" his potential in the bud," he wonders, how can he possibly have a "fruit[ful]" adulthood? Or, as he cries out to his "father and mother":

How shall the summer arise in joy,
Or the summer fruits appear?
Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
Or bless the mellowing year,
When the blasts of winter appear?

Overall, the [tone](#) of the boy's questions is both plaintive and challenging. It reflects the desperation of his situation, as well as his keen desire to persuade his parents to take him out of school. The key word in all these questions is "How," as in, *How can I go on like this?* or *How can you do this to me?*

Where Rhetorical Question appears in the poem:

- **Lines 16-30:** "How can the bird that is born for joy / Sit in a cage and sing? / How can a child, when fears annoy, / But droop his tender wing, / And forget his youthful spring! / O father and mother if buds are nipped, / And

blossoms blown away; / And if the tender plants are
stripped / Of their joy in the springing day, / By sorrow
and care's dismay,— / How shall the summer arise in joy, /
Or the summer fruits appear? / Or how shall we gather
what griefs destroy, / Or bless the mellowing year, /
When the blasts of winter appear?"

ALLITERATION

[Alliteration](#) accentuates a number of key lines in "The School Boy" and adds to the songlike musicality of the poem as a whole. In lines 3-5, for example, it adds a little extra lyricism to a passage about "sing[ing]":

The distant huntsman winds his horn,
And the skylark sings with me:
O what sweet company!

Later, the contrast between soft /s/ and hard /d/ alliteration ends lines 9-10 on a heavy, downbeat note, appropriate to the speaker's sad mood:

The little ones spend the day
In sighing and dismay.

Alliteration also features in the poem's central [rhetorical question](#), making it more musical and memorable:

How can the bird that is born for joy
Sit in a cage and sing?

Here, again, the alliteration falls on stressed syllables, accentuating the poem's [meter](#) and adding to the songlike quality of the language. This quality feels appropriate even in these lines about *struggling* to sing, because, of course, the speaker *wants* to sing. (Singing, here, is a [metaphor](#) for expressing one's "joy" and creative spirit.)

There's some prominent alliteration in the speaker's last rhetorical question, too:

Or how shall we gather what griefs destroy,
Or bless the mellowing year,
When the blasts of winter appear?

This time, guttural /g/ and plosive /b/ sounds give the passage a harsh, almost [cacophonous](#) quality. Indeed, the /b/ sounds recall those in line 22: "And the blossoms blown away." In both cases, the [imagery](#) involves a strong, destructive wind—a metaphor for hardships that weaken or "destroy" the human spirit. No wonder the language itself sounds percussive and violent, especially by contrast with the soft /h/ and /s/ alliteration of the first stanza.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** "huntsman," "horn"
- **Line 4:** "skylark sings"
- **Line 5:** "sweet"
- **Line 6:** "school," "summer"
- **Line 9:** "spend," "day"
- **Line 10:** "sighing," "dismay"
- **Line 11:** "sit"
- **Line 12:** "spend"
- **Line 16:** "bird," "born"
- **Line 17:** "Sit," "sing"
- **Line 21:** "buds"
- **Line 22:** "blossoms blown"
- **Line 23:** "stripped"
- **Line 24:** "springing," "day"
- **Line 25:** "sorrow," "dismay"
- **Line 28:** "gather," "griefs"
- **Line 29:** "bless"
- **Line 30:** "When," "blasts," "winter"



VOCABULARY

Morn (Line 1, Line 6) - Old-fashioned synonym of "morning."

Huntsman (Line 3) - Hunter.

Winds (Line 3) - Blows his horn (i.e., the horn traditionally used by hunters to signal their hounds).

Skylark (Line 4) - A type of small bird famous for singing in the early morning.

Outworn (Line 8) - Worn-out, weary, tired. Here, the adjective could apply either to "the little ones" or to the "cruel eye" of the teacher (but most likely applies to the teacher).

Learning's bower (Line 14) - A "bower" is a shady, pleasant spot amid trees or other greenery. [Metaphorically](#), "learning's bower" refers to the pleasure of learning, which has been destroyed by the "dreary" atmosphere of the schoolroom.

How can a child [...] But droop (Lines 18-19) - That is, *How can a child avoid drooping* (etc.).

Annoy (Line 18) - Harass or bother. (The word can also have an older, stronger meaning: "repeatedly attack.")

Care's (Line 25) - "Care" in this context refers to a state of worry or apprehension, while "dismay" refers to alarm, shock, or concern. "Care's dismay" thus refers to the general perturbation or consternation created by being full of worry.

Mellowing (Line 29) - Refers to the ripening of fruits; also [metaphorically](#) means "aging." Here, "the mellowing year" is a metaphor for older age (the autumn of one's life).

Blasts (Line 30) - Strong winds.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

The poem consists of six five-line stanzas, or [cinquains](#). These stanzas [rhyme](#) ABABB CDCDD, etc., and use a rough accentual meter with four or three stressed syllables per line. (The first and third lines of each stanza have four stressed syllables each; the others have three.) Hence, the form is a variant of the traditional poetic [ballad](#), which uses rhymed four-line stanzas ([quatrains](#)) with alternating four-beat and three-beat lines.

As its name implies, the ballad is a musical, songlike form (and is sometimes used in actual song lyrics). It began as very much a popular form, designed to be heard or read by a general audience, and it often features vivid dramatic characters, including speakers who are not the poet. All these things are true of Blake's variation on the ballad in "The School Boy." The poem is a dramatic monologue in relatively plain, approachable language, and it first appeared in Blake's *Songs of Experience*—a collection whose title reflects the songlike nature of its poems.

METER

"The School Boy" uses a bouncy accentual meter. The first and third lines of each [stanza](#) contain four **stressed** (accented) syllables, while the second, fourth, and fifth lines contain three (for the most part; there's variation throughout). At the same time, the total number of syllables in each line, and the placement of stresses, varies a bit.

Many, though not all, of the feet here fall into [iamb](#)s: that is, they feature an **unstressed-stressed** rhythm. As such, it's also possible to classify the poem as having a loose mixture of iambic tetrameter (four iambs per line) and iambic trimeter (three iambs per line).

Here's how this sounds in the first stanza, for example:

I love | to rise | in a sum- | mer morn,
When the birds | sing on | ever- | y tree;
The dis- | tant hunts- | man winds | his horn,
And the sky- | lark sings | with me:
O what | sweet com- | pany!

There's a recognizable beat, but a little bit of looseness and bounce built into it.

Here, this musical bounce (as well as the overall, [ballad](#)-like form of the poem) fits the character of the "School Boy," who likes to "sing[]" along with the birds. Of course, his free spirit is getting stifled by the dismal atmosphere of school—but the playful lilt of the [meter](#) hints that it hasn't been snuffed out quite yet.

RHYME SCHEME

The first and third lines of each five-line [stanza](#) rhyme with each

other, as do the second, fourth, and fifth lines. So the poem's general [rhyme scheme](#) is ABABB, etc.

There's one variation, however: lines 6 and 8 pick up on the A rhymes of the first stanza, so instead of ABABB CDCDD, the first two stanzas actually rhyme ABABB ADADD.

Most of the poem's [rhymes](#) are exact, but there's one slant rhyme ("sit"/"delight") in lines 11 and 13. These small variations, within a generally consistent rhyme scheme, might suggest a playful spontaneity trying to break through a strict pattern—much as the schoolboy's playful spirit longs to escape the strict confines of school.



SPEAKER

The poem announces its speaker in the title. This is a dramatic monologue written in the voice of an average 18th-century "School Boy," not the voice of the poet himself.

Like many children before and since, this schoolboy hates attending school, especially in the "summer." Unlike most children, he makes an extended, serious case that summer schooling is "cruel" and detrimental to his development. He does so in a pained address to his "father and mother," who are presumably forcing him to attend classes.

For the most part, he speaks in relatively simple, accessible, childlike language (though some of his [diction](#), such as "morn," sounds old-fashioned to 21st-century ears). When he's excited or unhappy, he bursts out in exclamations, just as real kids do (e.g., "O what sweet company!" or "O it drives all joy away!").

Of course, this is still a poem, so it contains some poetic flourishes an actual schoolboy probably wouldn't make—such as the elegant phrase "how shall we gather what griefs destroy." Here, Blake's dramatic monologue seems to ask for a little dramatic (or poetic) license!



SETTING

The [imagery](#) in the first [stanza](#) suggests that the poem takes place in the countryside. The "birds sing[ing] on every tree" and the "huntsman [blowing] his horn" (while pursuing foxes or other game) clearly point to a rural setting. The season is "summer"—a time when kids typically like to enjoy the outdoors.

Unfortunately for the speaker of this poem, he can't play outside: he's forced to go to school instead. He finds school dreary and prison-like, as though he were a "bird" in a "cage." His teacher is "cruel," and his classmates aren't enjoying themselves, either: "The little ones spend the day / In sighing and dismay."

In short, the poem incorporates and [juxtaposes](#) two contrasting [settings](#): the outdoor world of sunshine and freedom, and the

indoor (classroom) world of discipline and confinement. It argues that, during summer especially, the first is much healthier for children than the second.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

William Blake (1757-1827) is a poet unlike any other. Often considered one of the first of the English Romantics, he also stands apart from any movement as a unique philosopher, prophet, and artist.

Blake wrote "The School Boy" in 1789 and printed it in *Songs of Experience* (1794), one of his most famous and important works. This group of poems formed the second section of his collection *Songs of Innocence and of Experience*, a book that examines what Blake called "the two contrary states of the human soul."

Many of the poems in *Songs of Experience* have a counterpart in *Songs of Innocence*, a twin poem that reads the same subjects from a different perspective. For instance, "[The Lamb](#)" and "[The Tyger](#)" both explore creation, divinity, and nature, but in very different ways! This outraged tirade against child poverty has just such a cousin: the subtly [ironic](#) "[Holy Thursday](#)" of *Songs of Innocence*, in which a softhearted speaker is charmed by the sight of all those sweet orphans on their way to church.

Blake didn't just *write* poetry: he also designed, engraved, printed, painted, and published illuminated manuscripts using a technique he called the "infernal method." Blake painted his poems and pictures on copper plates with a resilient ink, then burned away the excess copper in a bath of acid—the opposite of the process most engravers used. But then, Blake often did the opposite of what other people did, believing that it was his role to "reveal the infinite that was hid" by custom and falsehood.

Even among the often countercultural Romantics, then, Blake was an outlier. Samuel Taylor Coleridge himself—no stranger to a [wild vision](#)—once remarked that he was "in the very mire of common-place common-sense compared with Mr. Blake."

While Blake was never widely known during his lifetime, he has become one of the most famous and beloved of poets since his death, and writers from [Allen Ginsberg](#) to [Olga Tokarczuk](#) to [Philip Pullman](#) claim him as a major influence.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

William Blake spent much of his life railing against the cruelties of 19th-century British society—and he had plenty to rail against.

The England of Blake's time was just getting caught up in the Industrial Revolution, a period during which the economy shifted from farming to manufacturing. The countryside began

to empty out, and the cities began to swell. English class divisions, always intense, began to seem even more pronounced as impoverished workers lived cheek-by-jowl with the fashionable and wealthy in newly crowded towns.

Workers during the early Industrial Revolution got a pretty raw deal. Even young children were forced to work in factories, dig in mines, and sweep chimneys (an absurdly dangerous job, contrary to the cheery Mary Poppins image many are familiar with: chimney-sweeps as young as three or four years old sometimes died of suffocation in narrow flues). Adults didn't have it much easier. With few regulations to keep factory owners in check, bosses could impose impossible working hours or withhold pay for any number of trifling offenses.

Throughout Blake's period, educational opportunities varied widely based on class, geography, and other factors. [According to](#) W. B. Stephens's *Education in Britain 1750-1914*, "schools of some kind were within geographical reach of all but comparatively few [British] children" by 1750. But many kids were forced to work rather than attend school, and even those who did receive an education, like the speaker of "The School Boy," often faced strict, discipline-heavy, or even "cruel" learning environments.

Blake's passionate, prophetic stance on humankind's innate divinity made him a fiery critic of the cruelty he saw all around him in his native London. And Blake was only one in a long series of writers who saw 19th-century education and labor conditions as an affront to humanity. Charles Dickens would later make similar protests in novels like [David Copperfield](#), [Hard Times](#), and [Oliver Twist](#).



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Blake Documentary](#) — Watch a feature on Blake's life, courtesy of the UK's South Bank Show. (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Qvx0on0Hj2I>)
- [The Poet's Life and Work](#) — A biography of William Blake at the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/william-blake>)
- [British Romanticism 101](#) — An introduction to the literary movement with which Blake is frequently associated. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/collections/152982/an-introduction-to-british-romanticism>)
- [The Poem, Illustrated](#) — Blake was a visual artist as well as a poet. Check out his hand-illustrated copy of "The School Boy." ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_School_Boy#/media/File:Songs_of_Innocence,_copy_B,_1789_\(Library_of_Congress\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_School_Boy#/media/File:Songs_of_Innocence,_copy_B,_1789_(Library_of_Congress)))
- [The Poem Sung!](#) — Famous 20th-century poet Allen

Ginsberg performs "The School Boy" as a song.
(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=chQaPT_Zjnk)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER WILLIAM BLAKE POEMS

- [A Dream](#)
- [Ah! Sun-flower](#)
- [A Poison Tree](#)
- [Earth's Answer](#)
- [Holy Thursday \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [Holy Thursday \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [Infant Joy](#)
- [Infant Sorrow](#)
- [Introduction \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [London](#)
- [Nurse's Song \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [Nurse's Song \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [The Chimney Sweeper \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [The Chimney Sweeper \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [The Clod and the Pebble](#)
- [The Divine Image](#)
- [The Ecchoing Green](#)
- [The Fly](#)
- [The Garden of Love](#)

- [The Lamb](#)
- [The Little Black Boy](#)
- [The Sick Rose](#)
- [The Tyger](#)
- [To Autumn](#)
- [To the Evening Star](#)



HOW TO CITE

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